

Kickoff — Activity Packet

Activity packet for facilitators. This file is the single source of truth for the half-day's three activities, including timing, deliverables, and facilitation cues.

Activity 1 — Two Truths and a TPM

Format: Pairs • 20 min • Opening block

Purpose

Two outcomes in one icebreaker: every participant leaves with at least one face-to-story association, and every participant has spoken about their product/engineering experience before the content begins. Avoids the round-the-room introductions trap that swallows the morning.

Setup

- Pair participants with someone they have not worked with. If the cohort is intra-company, enforce a "different team" rule.
- Distribute index cards (one per person) — they'll re-use them for Activity 3.

Steps

1. **Setup — 2 min.** Pairs sit facing each other. Each person silently writes three statements on their index card: two true, one false. All three must be about their product or engineering experience (not personal trivia).
2. **Round A → B — 8 min.** Person A reads their three statements. Person B picks the false one and asks **one** follow-up question on a true statement. No correction loop — partner just states their pick.
3. **Round B → A — 8 min.** Switch.
4. **Surface — 2 min.** Facilitator asks: "Who heard a truth they want everyone in the room to know?" Take 2–3 brief

shoutouts. Don't run the whole room.

Deliverable

The index card stays with the participant. They will re-use it for the Activity 3 quad commitment.

Facilitation cues

- If the room is uneven, make one trio: each shares once, each guesses twice.
- If the pair has worked together before, force a re-pair — Activity 1 fails if the partners already know each other's stories.
- Don't let pairs over-narrate. The 8-minute time-box is intentional — surface-level is fine.
- Resist the urge to do a "round of introductions" before this — it'll double the runtime and dilute the activity.

Common failure modes

- **Round-the-room creep.** Facilitator allows "let's just go around the room first." Don't. The pair-share is the introduction.
- **Personal-trivia drift.** "I have three cats" is not a TPM-academy introduction. Steer back to product/engineering experience.

Activity 2 — Where Have You Seen a TPM Win or Lose?

Format: Quartets • 30 min • Block 1

Purpose

Anchor the abstract framework of TPM failure modes in lived experience. By the time the cohort hits Week 1 Day 1, they should already have one or two stories — their own or others' — that they can map to the patterns we'll be teaching.

Setup

- Group the room into quartets. Random is fine; if there's a clear power-level imbalance (e.g., one senior with three juniors), reshuffle one person.

- Each quartet needs four index cards (separate from Activity 1's cards) or a shared notepad.

Steps

1. **Write — 5 min.** Each person writes a one-paragraph story (60-second read) about a real TPM, PM, or engineer doing TPM work who **won** or **lost** a decision. No names of real people or real customers. Just enough detail to make the decision concrete.
2. **Read silently — 5 min.** Cards/notes circulate around the quartet. No talking. No reactions. Just read.
3. **Pick + tag — 15 min.** The quartet picks **one** story. They identify which failure mode (from the deck) was in play — or its inverse (a "win" mode). They write a one-sentence diagnosis on the back of the card.
4. **Readouts — 5 min.** One quartet at a time, 90 seconds max: read the story aloud, then state the diagnosis. Move fast.

Failure modes to tag against

From the deck slide *Where TPMs Tend to Fail*:

1. Pre-deciding the solution
2. Misreading constraints
3. Hiding behind technical detail
4. Hiding behind customer empathy
5. Owning every artifact alone

The "inverse" of any of these (the win pattern) is equally valid for a winning story.

Deliverable

One story-with-diagnosis per quartet, surfaced in the readout. Capture these — they often resurface in later weeks as anchoring examples.

Facilitation cues

- If a quartet is stuck on "I don't have a story," prompt:
"Have you ever seen a feature launched that the engineering team didn't believe in? Why didn't they believe in it?"

- If a quartet picks a story but the diagnosis is generic ("communication was bad"), push for the specific failure pattern.
- Don't correct a quartet's diagnosis publicly — let the room hear it. You can offer a refinement later.

Common failure modes

- **Abstract opinions instead of stories.** "TPMs should always X" is not a story. Push for the specific decision and the specific person.
- **Story without diagnosis.** The quartet narrates but never tags. Hold them to the one-sentence diagnosis.

Activity 3 — Quad Formation + First Commitment

Format: Self-organize → quads • **25 min** • Block 2

Purpose

Form the working groups that carry through Week 3's mini-capstone PRD. The composition decision here directly affects the quality of Week 3 work — cognitively diverse quads outperform friend quads on every prior cohort.

Setup

- Have index cards (one per quad) and Sharpies at the front of the room.
- Have the composition rules visible on the screen during the activity.

Composition rules

A quad must include **at least one different dimension** across its four members:

1. **Experience level** — at least one with 3+ years in engineering-adjacent role, where possible
2. **Domain background** — different functional areas (e.g., not three from supply chain)
3. **Home team** — no two from the same home team if the cohort is intra-company

The bar is "at least one different dimension." A quad that's three engineers from the same team is forbidden. A quad that's three engineers from three teams is fine.

Steps

1. **Stand and mingle — 8 min.** Participants stand, walk the room, and form groups of three. Facilitator circulates and breaks up quads that violate composition rules.
2. **Sit + name — 5 min.** Each quad sits together. They give the quad a name (anything memorable — fast).
3. **Write the commitment — 8 min.** On a single index card, the quad writes a **one-sentence commitment** about how they will work together. Examples:
 - "We will tell each other when our drafts are weak, before peer review tells us."
 - "We will not let any one of us carry the PRD alone."
 - "We will surface disagreement before Friday."
4. **Share — 4 min.** Each quad reads their name and commitment to the room. Thirty seconds per quad, hard timebox.

Deliverable

A named quad with a one-sentence commitment card.

Photograph or collect the cards — they're a useful artifact for the Week 3 retrospective.

Facilitation cues

- The "stand and mingle" step is where cliques try to reform. Watch for two friends nodding at each other across the room — break it up before they settle.
- If the cohort is small (e.g., 9 people forming 3 quads), you may need to dictate composition rather than let it self-organize.
- A quad that produces a fluffy commitment ("we will try our best") should be asked to rewrite — the commitment is the artifact, and fluffy commitments are not useful in Week 3.
- Don't moralize about composition rules. Just enforce them quietly. Participants who get reshuffled will recognize the value by Week 2.

Common failure modes

- **Friend quads.** Three friends who already know each other form fast and produce comfortable but cognitively narrow Week 3 PRDs. Break them up.
- **Aspirational commitments.** "We will be excellent" is not a commitment — it's a wish. Push for a behavior they can act on.
- **Skipping the share.** The room-read makes the commitment public, which makes it sticky. Don't cut it for time.

What to do with the cards after the kickoff

Keep the cards through Week 3. At the Week 3 mini-capstone retrospective, hand each quad their original card and ask: "Did you keep the commitment? If not, what got in the way?" This is one of the more durable feedback loops the academy has.

Time-box reference card (print and bring)

Activity	Time	Group
1. Two Truths and a TPM	20 min	Pairs
2. Win or Lose	30 min	Quartets
3. Quad Formation	25 min	Quads

Total activity time: 75 minutes across the half-day. The remaining 135 minutes are teaching, transitions, break, and Q&A.

Virtual delivery — running the kickoff remotely

The activities above are written for an in-person room. The same three activities work virtually with a few translations. **All breakout-room assignments are random** (the video platform's auto-assign), not pre-mixed for diversity — this is the project's intentional choice.

Platform stack

- **Video conferencing** with breakout rooms — Zoom / Teams / Meet
- **One shared visual workspace** for the whole kickoff — Miro / FigJam / Mural (pre-build the boards described below). A shared Google Doc is a workable fallback if no whiteboard tool is available
- **Visible countdown timer** shown via screen-share for every timed step (any browser timer; an OBS overlay if you have one)

Universal virtual ground rules (state at 09:00 verbally + in chat)

- **Cameras on** for the whole kickoff. Set the expectation explicitly before Activity 1.
- **No notetaker bots.** Auto-join apps (Read AI, Otter, Fireflies, etc.) are more common on virtual calls than in-person — repeat the policy in chat as well as verbally and decline join requests.
- **Use chat as a parking lot** for questions that don't need to interrupt the flow.

Activity 1 — Two Truths and a TPM (virtual)

Format: Pairs • 20 min • Random breakout-room assignment

- **Breakout setup.** Facilitator uses the platform's auto-assign to create 2-person rooms. Set a 16-minute timer on the rooms; main-room broadcasts the 2-minute setup and 2-minute surface.
- **Index card substitute.** Each person types their three statements into the **breakout chat** (so both members can see them after the speaker has read them aloud). No Miro frame needed — chat is enough for two-person scope.
- **Steps stay identical** to the in-person version (Setup 2 min → A→B 8 min → B→A 8 min → Surface 2 min). The surface step happens in main room with the same chat / unmuted shoutouts.

Virtual-specific cues:

- If the room count is odd, the platform leaves one person solo — facilitator joins that room as a "third" and plays the partner role.

- Watch chat in main room for technical SOS during breakouts; one co-facilitator on chat watch is helpful but optional.

Activity 2 — Win or Lose (virtual)

Format: Quartets • 30 min • Random breakout-room assignment

- **Breakout setup.** Auto-assign 4-person rooms. 25-minute timer; main-room broadcasts the final 5-minute readout block.
- **Index card substitute.** Pre-build a **Miro board** before the kickoff with one frame per quartet (label them "Room 1 stories", "Room 2 stories", ...). Each frame has 4 sticky-note placeholders + a "Diagnosis" sticky at the bottom. Share the board link in chat at the start of the activity.
 - *Fallback if no whiteboard tool:* a single Google Doc with one section per quartet, 4 sub-headings per section for individual stories.
- **Step adjustments:**
 - **Write — 5 min.** Each person types their 60-second story into their assigned sticky / doc section. Cameras off OK to keep typing-attention.
 - **Read silently — 5 min.** Quartet members all read each other's stickies (Miro's "follow me" mode helps; in Docs, everyone scrolls).
 - **Pick + tag — 15 min.** Quartet discusses, picks one story, types the one-sentence diagnosis into the "Diagnosis" sticky.
- **Readouts (back in main room) — 5 min.** One person from each quartet **screen-shares their quartet's frame**, reads the story + diagnosis, 90 seconds max.

Virtual-specific cues:

- A facilitator should hop between breakout rooms during the 15-min discussion block — catches stuck quartets faster than waiting for chat SOS.
- If quartets struggle with the silent-read step, give them permission to use chat-reactions (👁️👁️ to acknowledge they've read each card).

Activity 3 — Quad Formation + First Commitment (virtual)

Format: Quads • 25 min • Random breakout-room assignment

The in-person "stand and mingle to find a quad" step doesn't translate. Use the platform's **random auto-assign for 3-person rooms** — that's the project's chosen approach. Trade-off acknowledged: random assignment doesn't enforce the "at least one different dimension" composition rule. Facilitators should be ready to coach quads whose composition turns out cognitively narrow.

- **Breakout setup.** Auto-assign 3-person rooms. 17-minute timer; main-room broadcasts a 5-min announce + 3-min stand-up readout window.
- **Announce — 5 min.** Facilitator explains: "Your breakout room is your quad. The platform mixed you randomly. You're together through end of Week 3."
- **In the breakout:**
 - **Sit + name — 5 min.** Quad picks a memorable name. (Skip the "sit together" step — they're already in a room.)
 - **Write the commitment — 8 min.** Each quad has a pre-built Miro **commitment card** (or Google Doc section) — one card per quad, labeled with a placeholder number that becomes the quad name. Quad collaboratively types its one-sentence commitment into the card.
 - **(Optional)** One member is "card keeper" — they screenshot the finished card and save it to a shared Drive folder for the Week 3 retro.
- **Share — 4 min.** Back in main room. Each quad reads name + commitment, 30 seconds each, unmuted. Same as in-person.

Virtual-specific cues:

- **Random assignment can produce friend-clusters by chance.** If a quad ends up obviously narrow (e.g., three engineers from the same team), the facilitator can either re-roll (move one person across quads) or coach them in-room to lean hard on the cognitive-diversity stretch. Decide which posture you want before kickoff.

- The commitment card is **the artifact** — preserve a screenshot or link in a shared folder. Without the physical card, it's easy to lose track of for the Week 3 retro.
- If a quad finishes early (~5 min), have them write a **stretch goal** on the same card: "we'll also ____" — gives extra quads something to do without disrupting the timer.

Virtual pre-flight checklist (in addition to the in-person checklist above)

- ☐ Pick ONE whiteboard tool and pre-build the boards: Activity 2 quartet frames, Activity 3 commitment cards
- ☐ Test the platform's breakout auto-assign for 2 / 4 / 3-person rooms before the cohort joins
- ☐ Visible countdown timer ready to screen-share for every timed step
- ☐ Have a co-facilitator (or yourself) on **chat watch** during breakouts for technical SOS
- ☐ Pre-create a **shared Drive folder** for screenshots of the quad commitment cards
- ☐ Test screen-share permissions in breakout rooms — some platforms require participants to be unmuted-and-promoted to share